

Payne College Professor Wins \$800,000 Award for Excellence in Literature

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Payne, Georgia — Jerry Landers, an English professor at Payne College and award-winning author, received the 2023 MacArthur Fellowship on Wednesday, given to the best literary scholars in the country.

The grant, according to the MacArthur Foundation, awards 30 new recipients each year with \$800,000 to fund their “intellectual, social, and artistic endeavors,” and has done so for over 40 years.

Landers has received multiple accolades for his work as an author, landing on The New York Times Best Seller list for *Messages from Ivan* and *The Last of the Moonlighters*, which received the Pulitzer Prize for fiction last year.

With the recent announcement of MacArthur's 2023 inductees, Landers is now one of 1,131 “fellows” to win the award, but despite his previous recognition, he was not expecting to win.

“I can't believe it was me,” said Landers, laughing as he described the moment he received the call. “I pick up the phone and suddenly I'm a genius.”

At 70 years old, Landers had already lived a long and diverse life. For decades, he worked as a purchaser for the Payne City Water Department, until the age of 55 when he was hired at Payne College, allowing him to pursue his lifelong passion for literature.

In 2014, Landers published his first novel, and since then, he has continued to release a new one every two years. He explained how amazed he was at his success as an author, considering it “doesn’t even feel like work” and he sees it more as a passion.

Landers’ colleagues at Payne College expressed their congratulations and praise for winning the MacArthur Fellowship, recognizing his dedication and talent in literature.

"This is a great day for Payne," said Mary Oswalt, the dean of the English department. "Jerry has helped our college out so much with this award."

While Landers has spent over 15 years inspiring many students at Payne College, his own story is just as remarkable. *The Last of the Moonlighters* follows the journey of a water department worker who retires to become a professor, and ultimately, a Pulitzer Prize winner.

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